Medieval England (1066–1485)

KNOWLEDGE RETRIEVAL & HOMEWORK COMPANION • 30 HIGH-YIELD QUESTIONS

Pupil Name: _____ **Class:** _____ **Teacher:** _____



The Bayeux Tapestry (c. 1070s) • Norman cavalry with stirrups and couched lances clash against the Anglo-Saxon shield wall at the Battle of Hastings (14 October 1066).

LESSON ENQUIRY FOCUS	HW DUE DATE	1. SOLO (WRITTEN)	2. PARTNER (VERBAL)	PARENT / TEACHER SIGN
Enquiry 1: 1066 & Battle of Hastings Edward's Death & Witan, Stamford Bridge, Anglo-Saxon Shield Wall, Feigned Retreat & Senlac Hill		/ 6	/ 6	
Enquiry 2: Castles, Terror & Domesday Motte & Bailey castles, Harrying of the North, 1086 Domesday Survey, Feudal Hierarchy & Tenant-in-Chief oaths		/ 6	/ 6	
Enquiry 3: Henry II & Thomas Becket Henry II, Archbishop Thomas Becket, Constitutions of Clarendon, Four Knights & Canterbury pilgrimage		/ 6	/ 6	
Enquiry 4: Magna Carta & King John King John, Barons' Revolt, Runnymede, Magna Carta (1215), Clause 39 & Rule of Law		/ 6	/ 6	
Enquiry 5: Black Death & Peasants' Revolt Yersinia pestis (1348), 40% mortality, Statute of Labourers (1351), 1381 Poll Tax & end of serfdom		/ 6	/ 6	

HOW TO COMPLETE YOUR RETRIEVAL CYCLES:

1. SOLO (WRITTEN): Complete your 6 write-in lines from memory without looking. Check your answers in green pen using the Department Marking Bank on Pages 7–8.

2. PARTNER (VERBAL): Hand your booklet to a **PARENT, CARER, FAMILY MEMBER, OR STUDY BUDDY** to test you out loud from the Marking Bank until you hit 6/6!

Scan for Interactive Digital Quizzes & Audio Lessons:
Access online self-marking retrieval flashcards, diagnostic feedback, and audio narration at the-history-revision-hub.netlify.app.

1. ► **Who was chosen by the Anglo-Saxon Witan to become King of England following the death of Edward the Confessor in January 1066?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

2. ► **At which Yorkshire battle did King Harold defeat Viking invader Harald Hardrada in late September 1066?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

3. ►► **What defensive formation did the Anglo-Saxons hold atop Senlac Hill that Norman cavalry repeatedly failed to break?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

4. ►► **How did Duke William use the tactic of the "feigned retreat" to break the Saxon shield wall?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

5. ►►► **Why was Duke William's military force superior to King Harold's traditional Anglo-Saxon army?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

6. ►►► **How did Harold's forced 200-mile march from Yorkshire to Sussex fatally undermine his chances at Hastings?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

KEY TERM VAULT: | Harold Godwinson | Stamford Bridge | Shield Wall | Feigned Retreat | Senlac Hill | Combined Arms

7. ► **What rapid type of earthwork and timber fortress did William build across England to intimidate conquered Saxon populations?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

8. ► **In what year was William the Conqueror's exhaustive national land and wealth survey, the Domesday Book, completed?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

9. ►► **What brutal scorched-earth campaign did William conduct in 1069–1070 to crush rebellion in Yorkshire and northern counties?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

10. ►► **Why did the Anglo-Saxons name William's comprehensive land audit the "Domesday Book"?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

11. ►►► **How did the Norman feudal land settlement completely replace the traditional Anglo-Saxon aristocracy?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

12. ►►► **How does chronicler Orderic Vitalis's account of the Harrying of the North challenge Norman propaganda?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

KEY TERM VAULT: Motte & Bailey | Harrying of the North | Domesday Book (1086) | Feudal Hierarchy | Tenants-in-Chief | Orderic Vitalis

13. ► **What supreme religious office in England was Thomas Becket appointed to by King Henry II in 1162?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

14. ► **What term described priests and monks accused of serious secular crimes such as robbery and murder who claimed exemption from royal courts?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

15. ►► **What 1164 legal charter did Henry II issue to force church courts and clergy under royal legal control?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

16. ►► **What fateful words did King Henry II reportedly utter in a furious rage that inspired four knights to ride to Canterbury?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

17. ►►► **Why was the brutal murder of Becket inside Canterbury Cathedral a catastrophic public relations disaster for Henry II?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

18. ►►► **Who ultimately triumphed in the power struggle between the medieval Crown and the Catholic Church?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

KEY TERM VAULT: | Thomas Becket | Archbishop of Canterbury | Criminous Clerks | Constitutions of Clarendon | Four Knights | Canterbury Pilgrimage

19. ► **In what year and at which meadow near Windsor was King John forced to seal Magna Carta (the Great Charter)?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

20. ► **What controversial tax did King John repeatedly levy on barons who chose not to fight in his unsuccessful French wars?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

21. ►► **Why did King John's catastrophic defeat at the Battle of Bouvines (1214) trigger immediate baronial rebellion in England?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

22. ►► **What fundamental constitutional principle did Clause 39 of Magna Carta establish regarding justice and imprisonment?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

23. ►►► **Why was Magna Carta fundamentally a conservative document that accidentally created modern human rights?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

24. ►►► **How did Magna Carta permanently change the legal balance of power between the English monarch and the law?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

KEY TERM VAULT: | King John | Magna Carta (1215) | Runnymede | Scutage (Shield Money) | Clause 39 | Rule of Law |

25. ► **In what year did the deadly bubonic and pneumonic plague known as the Black Death arrive in England?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

26. ► **What radical priest preached the equality of all people during the 1381 Peasants' Revolt asking: "When Adam delved and Eve span, who was then the gentleman?"**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

27. ►► **Why did the massive loss of population during the Black Death shift economic power into the hands of surviving peasants?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

28. ►► **What oppressive royal statute did Parliament pass in 1351 to freeze peasant wages at pre-plague levels?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

29. ►►► **Why did the introduction of a third, regressive Poll Tax in 1381 ignite the violent Peasants' Revolt in Essex and Kent?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

30. ►►► **Why was the Peasants' Revolt a decisive historical turning point even though Wat Tyler was murdered and the rebellion crushed?**

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

KEY TERM VAULT: Yersinia pestis (1348) | Miasma Theory | Statute of Labourers (1351) | Poll Tax (1381) | Wat Tyler & John Ball | End of Serfdom

Department Marking Bank • Part 1

Green-Pen Verification Key • Enquiries 1 to 3 (Questions 1 to 18)

ENQUIRIES 1–3

ENQUIRY 1: 1066 & BATTLE OF HASTINGS

1. ► **Harold Godwinson, Earl of Wessex** — *Harold was crowned Harold II, claiming Edward promised him the crown, triggering invasions from Norway and Normandy.* [✓] [X]

2. ► **The Battle of Stamford Bridge** — *Harold surprised the Norse invaders, crushing the Viking threat but leaving his army depleted and exhausted.* [✓] [X]

3. ►► **The shield wall** — *Housecarls and peasant fyrd locked wooden shields tightly together along the ridge, creating a barrier against Norman arrows and lances.* [✓] [X]

4. ►► **Norman cavalry pretending to flee downhill, tricking undisciplined Saxons into breaking ranks to pursue them** — *When Saxon fyrdmen rushed downhill, Norman knights wheeled around on horseback and slaughtered the isolated infantry in open ground.* [✓] [X]

5. ►►► **William deployed combined-arms tactics (cavalry, archers, and infantry), whereas Harold lacked cavalry and archers** — *Norman archers firing high into the air forced Saxons to lift their shields, exposing them to lethal cavalry charges and arrow strikes.* [✓] [X]

6. ►►► **His elite housecarls were heavily depleted and his surviving troops were physically exhausted before battle began** — *Marching 400 miles in three weeks left Harold without time to muster the full southern fyrd before confronting fresh Norman invaders.* [✓] [X]

ENQUIRY 2: CASTLES, TERROR & DOMESDAY

7. ► **Motte-and-bailey castles** — *Norman garrisons could erect these defensive wooden palisades atop an earthen mound within eight to ten days using forced local labour.* [✓] [X]

8. ► **1086** — *Commissioned at Christmas 1085, Domesday catalogued every manor, plow, mill, and pig across England to maximize tax revenue.* [✓] [X]

9. ►► **The Harrying of the North** — *William ordered crops burned, livestock slaughtered, and soil salted, causing over 100,000 northern people to perish from starvation.* [✓] [X]

10. ►► **Its legal verdicts were absolute and unchangeable, like the Day of Judgement (Doomsday)** — *No appeal was permitted against the written record of the King's commissioners, establishing the bureaucratic power of the Crown.* [✓] [X]

11. ►►► **Dispossessing 4,000 Saxon thegns and reallocating all land to roughly 200 Norman baronial tenants-in-chief** — *By 1086, less than 5% of English land remained in Anglo-Saxon hands, establishing a French-speaking ruling class over an English peasantry.* [✓] [X]

12. ►►► **Condemning William's brutal starvation of innocent women and children as an unforgivable sin against God** — *Despite being half-Norman, Vitalis wrote that no earthly glory could pardon the cold-blooded starvation of an entire civilian population.* [✓] [X]

ENQUIRY 3: HENRY II & THOMAS BECKET

13. ► **Archbishop of Canterbury** — *Henry expected his former close friend and Chancellor to support the Crown against the Church, but Becket transformed into a fierce defender of the Papacy.* [✓] [X]

14. ► **Criminous clerks** — *Roughly one-sixth of England's male population claimed clerical immunity, receiving light penances in church courts rather than hanging in royal courts.* [✓] [X]

15. ►► **The Constitutions of Clarendon** — *Henry decreed that clerics convicted in church courts should be handed to secular sheriffs for punishment, which Becket refused to sign.* [✓] [X]

16. ►► **"Will no one rid me of this turbulent priest?"** — *Four royal knights took the king's outburst literally, traveling to Canterbury Cathedral to arrest Becket on 29 December 1170.* [✓] [X]

17. ►►► **The Pope threatened excommunication, forcing Henry to perform public penance and abandon his legal reforms over clergy** — *Henry had to walk barefoot through Canterbury while monks scourged his back with rods, and Becket's tomb became Europe's most famous pilgrimage shrine.* [✓] [X]

18. ►►► **The Catholic Church maintained its legal independence and supremacy over secular monarchs throughout the Middle Ages** — *Becket's martyrdom cemented the authority of papal canon law and the independence of the Church until Henry VIII's Reformation 350 years later.* [✓] [X]

Department Marking Bank • Part 2

Green-Pen Verification Key • Enquiries 4 to 5 (Questions 19 to 30)

ENQUIRIES 4–5

ENQUIRY 4: MAGNA CARTA & KING JOHN

19. ► **1215 at Runnymede** — *Rebel barons captured London and forced John to negotiate on a water meadow alongside the River Thames.* [✓] [X]

20. ► **Scutage (shield money)** — *John levied scutage eleven times in sixteen years to pay foreign mercenaries, while losing English territories in Normandy.* [✓] [X]

21. ►► **It bankrupted John's treasury and destroyed any hope of reclaiming his lost ancestral lands in France** — *Barons who paid heavy scutage realized John had wasted their wealth, leaving him politically defenseless against armed rebellion.* [✓] [X]

22. ►► **No free man could be imprisoned, outlawed, or seized except by lawful judgment of his peers or the law of the land** — *Clause 39 created the foundation of trial by jury and habeas corpus, outlawing arbitrary royal arrest and confiscation.* [✓] [X]

23. ►►► **Barons intended only to protect aristocratic feudal privileges, but its universal language later safeguarded all citizens** — *While the 1215 barons cared only for their own taxes and estates, the phrasing "no free man" became the bedrock of modern constitutional liberty.* [✓] [X]

24. ►►► **It established that the monarch is not above the law but bound by the law of the land** — *It set the crucial precedent that English kings could not exercise arbitrary absolutism without baronial and parliamentary consent.* [✓] [X]

ENQUIRY 5: BLACK DEATH & PEASANTS' REVOLT

25. ► **1348 (entering via the port of Melcombe Regis, Dorset)** — *Carried by fleas on black rats, the bacterium Yersinia pestis wiped out between 30% and 50% of the entire English population in under two years.* [✓] [X]

26. ► **John Ball** — *Ball attacked the feudal hierarchy, demanding the abolition of serfdom, equal wealth distribution, and church land confiscation.* [✓] [X]

27. ►► **Acute labour shortages meant landowners had to compete for workers by offering higher wages and better terms** — *Uncut crops rotted in fields; when lords refused to pay, peasants simply walked away to neighboring manors offering coin.* [✓] [X]

28. ►► **The Statute of Labourers (1351)** — *Landlords ordered imprisonment and heavy fines for peasants demanding market wages, sparking decades of bitter working-class resentment.* [✓] [X]

29. ►►► **It taxed rich and poor identical sums of one shilling per person to fund costly, failing French wars** — *A poor laborer earning pennies had to pay the exact same tax as a wealthy knight, triggering armed uprisings led by Wat Tyler.* [✓] [X]

30. ►►► **Parliament never dared to levy another poll tax, and landowners gradually commuted serfdom into free wage labour** — *Fear of renewed peasant insurrection forced landlords to abandon unpaid feudal bondage, leading to the extinction of English serfdom by 1450.* [✓] [X]

UNIT CONCEPTUAL FOUNDATIONS • 4 CORE ANCHORS

FEUDALISM: A rigid social hierarchy where the King owned all land, granting it to Norman tenants-in-chief in exchange for military service and oath-bound loyalty.

CHIVALRY: The medieval knightly religious, moral, and social code that governed aristocratic warfare, courage, piety, and honor on the battlefield.

RULE OF LAW: The constitutional principle established by Magna Carta (1215) that even the King is subject to the law of the land and cannot govern arbitrarily.

SERFDOM: The legal status of medieval peasants (villeins) who were bound to their lord's land, performing unpaid labour in return for a small plot and protection.